



Intro to Indigenous Engagement, Relations, and Cultural Awareness



Proven strategies for building trust, consensus, and conflict resolution

Lakehead University
March 2026

Land Acknowledgement & Roundtable Introductions



Introduction to Indigenous Culture: Indigenous Worldviews

- Connection to land and place
 - Land as identity
 - Reciprocal relationships
 - Land can be sacred
- Interconnectedness
- Balance





Introduction to Indigenous Culture: Indigenous Worldviews

- Spiritual Understanding
 - Animism
 - Sacred Relationships
 - Ceremony and ritual
 - Gratitude and humility
- Oral storytelling



The 8 Grandfather Teachings of Treaty 3

- **Respect** – Buffalo
- **Love** – Eagle
- **Wisdom** – Beaver
- **Bravery** – Bear
- **Honesty** – Raven
- **Humility** – Wolf
- **Truth** – Turtle
- **Forgiveness** – Rock: A unique Treaty 3 teaching, representing healing, carrying history, and moving forward.





Introduction to Indigenous Culture: Indigenous Worldviews

- Traditional Ecological/Indigenous Knowledge (TEK/TIK) gained over thousands of years of careful observation
- Adaptive management that responds to environmental changes
- Sustainable practices



Current Trends



All photos taken from CBC articles cited and linked in notes.



Practical Engagement Strategies: Research and Preparation Phase

- Do your research on the community and its history before reaching out or meeting with them
- Know your own work, project, technical details, environmental impacts, and any potential benefits and be able to communicate complex ideas in terms the community can understand
- Ask for advice from more experienced or knowledgeable people if you're not comfortable:
 - Find out which Tribal Council the community is affiliated with, reach out to them and ask for advice or guidance
 - Call the band office, introduce yourself, and ask for help
 - Reach out to Garrett
- Know how to dress appropriately for the meeting – don't underdress or overdress with respect to formality
- After doing some research, it might not hurt to ask the community directly for advice on how to engage and move forward



Practical Engagement Strategies: Trust and Relationship Building

- Many (but not all) First Nation communities have a general lack of trust for government and industry
- It takes years to build trust with communities that is resilient and authentic, and it only takes 5 minutes to lose it
- There are dozens of trust and relationship building activities that may be considered at different times when appropriate to do so: *build personal relationships before business relationships*
 - Always lead with open, honest dialogue, and if you don't know the answer to a question – say so and commit to trying to find one
 - Follow through on any commitments made and engage in good faith
 - Traditional gift giving (i.e., gifting a piece of Indigenous artwork like a blanket to a Chief and Council at the first meeting if you have requested the meeting); it's the thought and the action that counts
 - Ask about their local traditional protocols or how they prefer to engage or consult, and seek to meaningfully implement wherever feasible
 - Express interest in paying Elder honoraria to have Elders open meetings with prayers and smudging (or something similar they can do), and using local community members to prepare meals served at the meeting



Practical Engagement Strategies: Consensus Building



Practical Engagement Strategies: Early Engagement to Manage Risk

- Risk can take many forms: risk of surprising a First Nation person on their trapline while prospecting during hunting season, risk of making a community feel threatened by advanced exploration activities without a social license, risk to project continuity from legal challenges from FN communities, and investor risk
- It's important to understand and manage risk, especially for larger projects with longer time horizons and investor relations
- Generally, the earlier someone can engage with First Nations regarding a specific mining claim or exploration activity, the better
- Time and effort spent on building genuine trust and personal relationships with leadership and key influential people in the community almost always pays off later
- Evidence demonstrates that early engagement with Indigenous communities reduces risk to project timeline delays and legal fees in court



Practical Engagement Strategies: Early Engagement to Manage Risk

- Mining projects with early Indigenous engagement experience 30–50% fewer delays and cost overruns¹
- Companies report 10-fold return on investment in Indigenous partnership programs²
- Early engagement reduces legal challenges by up to 75%³
- Projects with Indigenous partnerships achieve faster permitting approvals and stronger social license to operate⁴

Scenario I: Seemingly low risk & simple

Prospecting for gold

You're a prospector, outdoors enthusiast, and excited to be collecting samples on a mining claim that the Ministry of Mines fulfilled the duty to consult on. While navigating through the bush, you encounter an Indigenous person who says that you're on their trapline and asks what you're doing. After introducing yourself, the trapper tells you that you're negatively impacting his treaty rights to hunt, fish, and trap as protected by Section 35 of the Constitution Act, 1982, and to get off his trapline.

How do you immediately respond, and what are your next 3 moves?





Scenario II: Moderate risk and complexity

**Relationship agreement
negotiations have stalled,
community has lawyered up**

See speaker's notes.

*How do you immediately
respond, and what are your
next 3 moves?*



Scenario III: Strategic Issues & Reputation Management, Risk Mitigation and Scenario Planning



Advanced exploration activities suddenly halted; high stakes

See speaker's notes.

How do you immediately respond, and what are your next 10 moves?

Health Break and General Q & A